Nine Hours to Fallujah

By Craig McNulty

CHARACTERS

MAUREEN JACKSON *(aka "Mo"): twenty-two, marine reservist. She wants to be a teacher. She was part of a convoy that was attacked by insurgents, where she fought bravely and remained very calm and very cool - what Hemingway would've called grace under fire.*

BRIAN ALYESWORTH: *twenty-one, Marine reservist. Engineering major and film fanatic, but the type of guy who would be more into Scarface than Breathless.*

TIME: *November 8, 2004, 9:30 PM*

SETTING: *Iraq, U.S.A. military camp just outside of Fallujah*

INTRODUCTION

Actor: As of September 2010, 4,427 US soldiers have been killed in Iraq. 54% of that number were under the age of 25. With attacks coming as swiftly as they do randomly, fear can be a constant companion for many soldiers.

Actress: Soldiers know that blood and death come with the job. – But what if you find something else during the war? What if you find love?

Actor: To date more than 182,000 women have served in Iraq, Afghanistan and the surrounding region. With the fear of death a constant companion, it is human nature to find solace and relationships with others.

Actress: In Nine Hours to Fallujah by Craig McNulty two young soldiers, Maureen (Mo) and Brian discuss their feelings for each other and their fears of war.

Together: Nine Hours to Fallujah by Craig McNulty

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AT RISE: Sounds of explosions to a black stage. Lights come up on Brian (twenty-one) seated on an army blanket and writing in a journal. He has his shoes off and has articles spread around the blanket (towels, shirts, food rations). Coming up behind him is Maureen (a.k.a. "Mo") (twenty-two) holding a handgun. Brian is consumed with writing in his journal and doesn't see her. She is looking intensely at him. She puts the gun away, takes a swig off a flask, and begins to sneak up on him. Even as she is standing right behind him and reading over his shoulder Brian still doesn't know she's there. She grabs him under his arm and says -

MO: Private Alyesworth. *(Brian jumps, sending his book flying.)*

BRIAN: Jesus Christ Mo! You scared the living shit outta me.

MO: See, if I was a suicide bomber, you'd be dead.

BRIAN: If you were a suicide bomber we'd both be dead.

MO: Yea, but, you be burning in the infidel fires of hell and I'd be in Allah's paradise.

BRIAN: With the rivers of honey and the seventy-two virgins?

MO: Yep. But I don't get how that's supposed to be an incentive, I mean, I'm not gay or even an occasional switch-hitter, so the seventy-two hottie Arab chicks don't do it for me. And seventy-two male virgins, what would that be, seventy-two teenage Arab boys who's idea of *passion* is throwing me to the ground for a session of amour that lasts all of sixty-four seconds? Wow, whoopee, that's a *heck of* a paradise for a girl to look forward to.

BRIAN: Maybe the men would look like Omar Sharif or Valentino.

MO: *(Considers this.)* Yea ... Nah, that still doesn't do it for me. *(Interrupted by three particularly loud explosions in the distance.)* I don't think the locals will be too happy to see the Stars and Stripes tomorrow.

BRIAN: Softening the enemy is the going expression ... Yea, probably as effective as kicking a junkyard dog a couple of times thinking it's going to make him more docile.

MO: I understand the General gave a riveting speech yesterday

BRIAN: Invoking the usual suspects: sands of Iwo Jima, shores of Tripoli, John Wayne, John Rambo.

MO: He's seen *Patton* a few too many times.

BRIAN: The general was a "hero" in the epic war against Grenada. Two years

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ago smoking and watching *Full Metaljacket* never thought I would be in this position.

MO: None of us did Bri ... Just pay close attention to the children.

BRIAN: What?

MO: When the main fighting is going on they'll be gone. When things calm down and you'll see kids around, then the area is probably clear. Not absolutely but probably ... but if the kids are around, then they all suddenly seem to split, that's when you know *it* is definitely hitting the fan.

BRIAN: OK.

MO: The first time you see someone shooting at you, I mean you can see their face, you're going to be tempted to go for a head shot, don't. Just remember like it was back in basic and aim for the torso ... *(Mo's now looking through Brian's CD case.)* Jesus, Limp Bisket isn't really your favorite band, is it?

BRIAN: What? Oh, not really. Jerry gave it to me, said it was good rolling out music.

MO: I would just hate to think of anyone dying and the last thing they listened to is Limp Bisket. *(Mo throws CD upstage.)*

BRIAN: Mo!

MO: Or Eminem, he's such an *idiot*. *(Mo throws Eminem CD as well.)*

BRIAN: Mo, will you stop *messing* with my *stuff*!

MO: OK, just trying to help.

BRIAN: Just don't touch my stuff.

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MO: If you had one thing to listen to before you checked out what would it be?

BRIAN: I don't know. Maybe something by U2 or maybe Nirvana ... tough question.

MO: It is a tough question. When I'm feeling down I listen to Bob Marley and I feel better, or I listen to Bright Eyes and it makes me feel worse ... but in a good way.

BRIAN: Who is Bright Eyes?

MO: It's the music I played that night, don't you remember?

BRIAN: Yea, I remember. *(Mo takes letter out of her pocket.)*

MO: So, I found this under my pillow ...

BRIAN: Yea, well, you weren't supposed to read it till Thursday. See where it says on the outside, Do not read till Thursday?

MO: Well you didn't date it genius, so for all I knew you meant last Thursday which would've made it a OK for me to read it today.

BRIAN: Oh, is that it? Guess I should've been more specific.

MO: Guess so, and who do you know that would get a letter that says don't open till Thursday and would actually wait for Thursday?

BRIAN: I had this nightmare. I had it more than once. There's all these soldiers who've had their arms, legs, and faces blown off, and they're burned ... badly. I'm nervous to see them. I'm afraid to be in the same room with them because I'm afraid I'll lose *it* and come off looking like a wuss. So all these dismembered soldiers are dressed up in various outfits, like Hawaiian shirts and football jerseys told how good they look and wheeled around to try to make them feel better, and the whole thing is horrific ...

MO: It's like so OK to be scared the night before, you wouldn't be human if

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you…

BRIAN: Been really sensitive last few days to sensations in my fingers and toes

MO: Is there something wrong with

BRIAN: There's nothing wrong, I've just been thinking I don't wanna go home like Stevens or Washington ...

MO: Or like that guy in *The Sun Also Rises*.

BRIAN: Who was in that?

MO: I don't know, it wasn't a movie.

BRIAN: I think it was.

MO: Jesus, did you ever have to take a liberal arts class or have a summer reading list?

BRIAN: Yea, but that's why God invented Cliff Notes, right?

MO: Whatever ... in the book by Hemingway the protagonist gets his genitals blown off in World War One? His equipment isn't up for the job anymore ...

BRIAN: Thanks Mo, that's a *heck of* story to tell someone the night before a major operation.

MO: *Sorry* sorry sorry, I know, bad Mo, mouth going before I was thinking.

BRIAN: Yea, well, anything like that and I want you *to*

MO: *Now*, getting shot in the leg, the fleshy part, not hitting bone, if you had to get it that would be the best place to get shot, with as Iowa caliber as possible. You'd get a Purple Heart and a one-way trip to Germany with that one.

BRIAN: Listen Mo, I'm Catholic ...

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MO: OK, and I'm a Methodist, what does that got to do with anything

BRIAN: *If* my legs or arms or face were blown off I'd just as quick stick my gun in my mouth and blow my brains to Syria . . . but being a Roman Catholic ya can't kill yourself I guess you can kill as many other cats as you want and still see heaven just not yourself

MO: Never thought of you as being very religious.

BRIAN: Mo, a hot shot of as much morphine as you can get a hold of and just let me go off to sleep.

MO: *(Furious)* How can you ask me to do something like that?!

BRIAN: I just thought that we, I'm asking you because

MO: It wasn't the booze.

BRIAN: The?

MO: *I* just wanted you to *knowl*

BRIAN: *That?*

MO: *I* wasn't with you for an evening's entertainment or ... it wasn't like that for me.

BRIAN: Yea, well, me too. For an evening's "entertainment" I usually play poker or something, but not that.

MO: I don't want you to think because I'm saying no to this that I don't

BRIAN: *OK OK OK*, it's fine, really.

MO: Can we just talk, like talk talk for a few minutes?

BRIAN: What difference would it make?

MO: Because if we were at school together and you were getting into a bus and riding out of town for summer break it wouldn't be a big deal, right? Sure,

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I might get killed in a car accident or OD on meth, but chances are none of that would happen. Chances are whatever we'd wanna work out between *us*,

BRIAN: *So* it was a big favor to ask of you and you don't feel too swell about I doing it, fine. I don't know if I could look into your eyes and do it for you, but right now there's nothing else to talk about.

MO: Brian, it's just more complicated than how I feel about *you*

BRIAN: *You* wanna tell me, what? That you don't sleep around? Great, thank you. I never thought you did. A few hours from now that information is going to be useful to me ... how?

MO: Yea ... no ... I don't know ... *(Brian goes back to messing around with his backpack, Mo gets up and begins to leave.)* We'll always have Iraq ... during the winter time ... in the middle of the Jihad right?

BRIAN: Right. *(Brian stops putzing with his bag, stands up.)* You know I've never seen *Casablanca.*

MO: Really?

BRIAN: Nope, just never got around to it. *(Mo takes a long look at Brian.)*

MO: You will. Trust me.

BRIAN: Maybe.

MO: Did you mean what you wrote at the bottom of the letter?

BRIAN: Yea, but I think you knew that already. *(Mo slowly walks over to Brian, she runs her hand over his face and they share an intense kiss.)*

MO: I love you, too. *(Mo exits quickly stage right.)*

BRIAN: Maureen, wait! *(Brian goes to grab his boots to chase her when he is shot*

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in the leg, in the calf) AHH!!! *(Three sharp whistle blasts from stage right.)*

MO: *(Offstage.)* Sniper Action Northwest Corner, incoming! *(Prolonged machine-gun blasts offstage, Mo enters stage right with her weapon drawn and kneels next to wounded Brian.)*

BRIAN: MO! What did you do?! *(Mo grabs a towel and begins to wrap Brian's leg.)*

MO: I got you covered baby, don't worry, I got you covered. *(Lights to black as machine-gun bursts continue)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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